

Before you call a roofer

Water shows up on a ceiling and somebody has to decide what it is. Here is what to call about today, what can wait, and what is not a roof leak at all.

Call now

TODAY

- Water coming into a unit right now.
- A tenant standing under an active drip.
- Shingles, panels, siding or flashing on the ground after a storm.
- An ice dam with water getting inside.

Call this week

DAYS

- A ceiling stain that is not growing.
- Granules in the gutters or below a downspout.
- Flashing lifted, bent or pulled away from a wall.
- A pipe boot cracked, split or missing its collar.

On the schedule

PLANNING

- A roof near the end of its life.
- Before a sale, refinance or lease.
- After hail in the area, even if nothing shows from the ground.
- While next year's budget is set.

Probably not the roof THE CALL WORTH NOT MAKING

Most ceiling stains get blamed on the roof and plenty of them are something else. **Some of these are still our work, because we do siding as well as roofing. Some are not, and we will say so.**

NOT THE ROOF, BUT STILL US

No kick out flashing where a roof meets a wall

The bent metal that should throw water off the roof edge into the gutter is missing, so it runs behind the siding instead. The wall soaks and the stain turns up a floor below while the roof itself tests fine.

Storm or wind damage to siding

The wind that lifts shingles also cracks and pulls panels, and a loose panel lets driven rain in behind the wall. Same weather, same visit, same contractor.

Ice dams, and the venting behind them

The roof is not failing, the attic is warm. Melt runs down, refreezes at the cold eave and backs water up under the shingles. Ridge vent and soffit intake are ours. The insulation letting that heat up is not, and a new roof over a warm attic dams again.

NOT THE ROOF, AND NOT US

A bath or kitchen fan venting into the attic

Warm wet air hits the cold underside of the deck, condenses and drips back down. It looks exactly like a leak, and it happens on dry days.

An HVAC condensate line or drain pan

A plugged line or a rusted pan above a ceiling overflows and stains it. The tell is the season, worst on the hottest days rather than the wettest ones.

A plumbing vent or supply line in the wall

A stain directly under a bathroom or a kitchen on the floor above is plumbing until proven otherwise. It does not wait for rain.

A window head, a sill or a failed sealant joint

Water entering at the top of a window runs down inside the wall and shows up on a ceiling below, sometimes a room away.

Quickest test is timing. Cold and dry means condensation, hot with cooling on means HVAC, only in rain means the roof.

WHEN YOU CALL US

- 1 We come out and look at it with you.
- 2 We get on the roof, and on the walls.
- 3 We photograph it slope by slope.
- 4 You get a written, itemized estimate.

If it is neither the roof nor the siding, the report says so. You will not get an estimate for work you do not need.

Roof record

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